The Civic Architecture Blueprint for AI
Governing Artificial Intelligence in High-Stakes Public Services
A 4D Strategic Playbook based on the Northbridge City Civic Atlas.
Gemini Notebook

The Fundamental Asymmetry of Government AI

Private-sector AI can break things.
The cost is a lost customer or a failed transaction.

Government AI breaks lives.
A failed model denies a benefit, misfiles a permit, or flags an innocent taxpayer.

Core Takeaway: Government possesses a monopoly on public services. Citizens cannot take their business elsewhere. Therefore, government AI must be adopted at the speed of trust, built with evidence, and published in plain langu

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The Core Paradigm: AI Prepares, Humans Decide

AI's Domain:
Prepares, Checks, Drafts, Summarizes.
AI handles the volume work of archaeology—reading forms, matching evidence, checking completeness, and drafting initial responses.

Human's Domain:
Decides, Signs, Answers, Overrides.
The human officer retains all statutory authority, exercising judgrment, signing the fina final letter, and owning the outcome.

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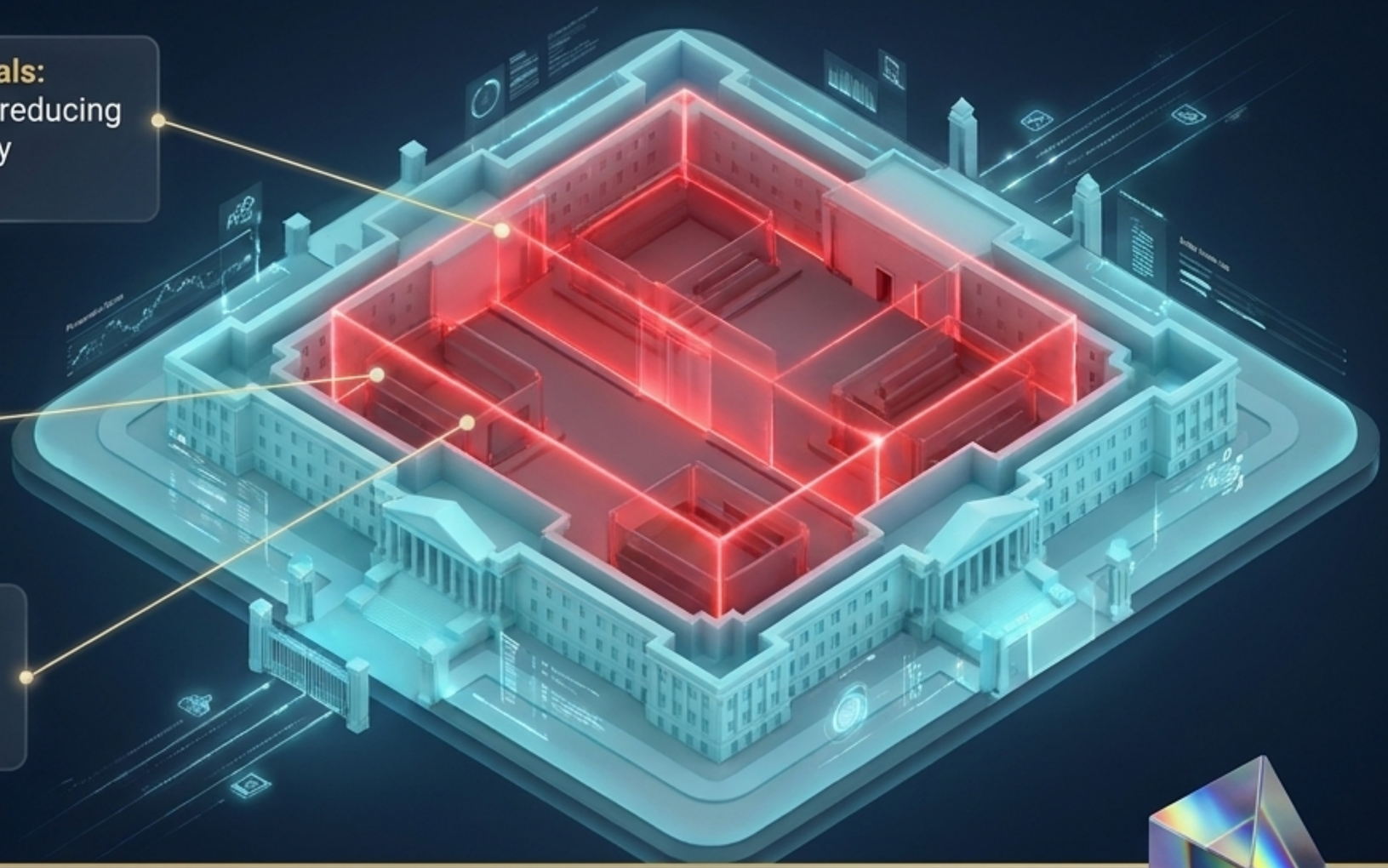
Statutory Boundaries are Red Lines, Not Guidelines

No Automated Refusals:
Granting, refusing, or reducing a benefit is a statutory human judgment.

No Automated Penalties:
Sanctions, fraud findings, and overpayment recovery require human hardship weighing.

No Safeguarding Determinations:
Suspicion is not evidence.
AI flags anomalies; humans investigate.



If a resident is entitled to ask "who decided this?", a human must be able to answer with the record in hand.

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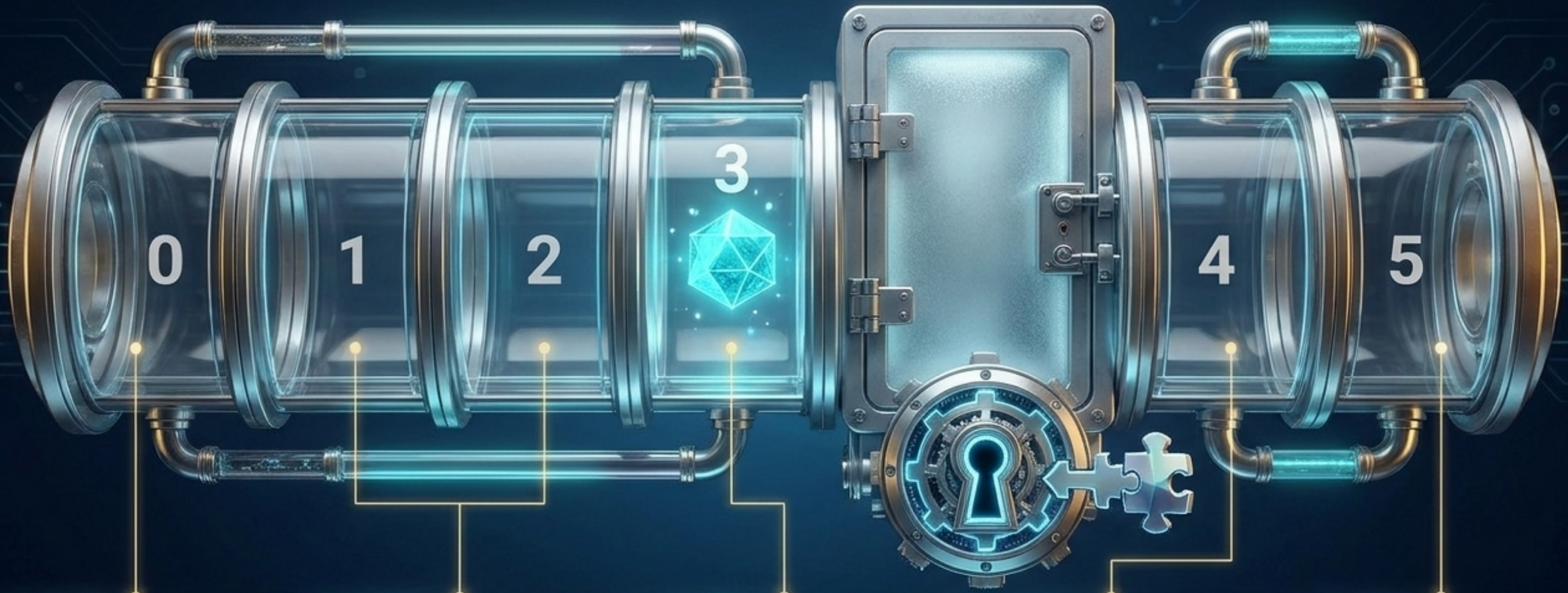
The Assurance Pipeline Requires Evidence, Not Enthusiasm



Airlock 0 (Mandate): Is this use lawful, wanted, and owned? Requires named owner, signed Stop List.

Airlock 1 & 2 (Design & Readiness): Are rules, data, and records sound? Requires rules traced to law.

Airlock 3 (Proof): Does it work on real cases? Requires shadow running against human decisions.

Airlock 4 (Controlled Live): Does it hold under load? Requires appeal causes monitored weekly.

Airlock 5 (Scale): Has it earned wider use? Requires two quarters of published equity and right-first-time data.

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A Resident Experiences One Government, Not Nine Departments

The "Ask Once" Principle:
Data the government already holds is pre-filled. The resident tells their story once per case, regardless of channel switching.

Grounded AI Assistants:
Assistants retrieve answers only from the approved, versioned content store. No open-web hallucinations. Every answer carries a visible citation.

Seamless Handoff:
When a citizen transfers from digital to a **live agent**, the AI provides a one-page summary.
Result: Residents repeat an average of 0.3 facts (down from 2.7).

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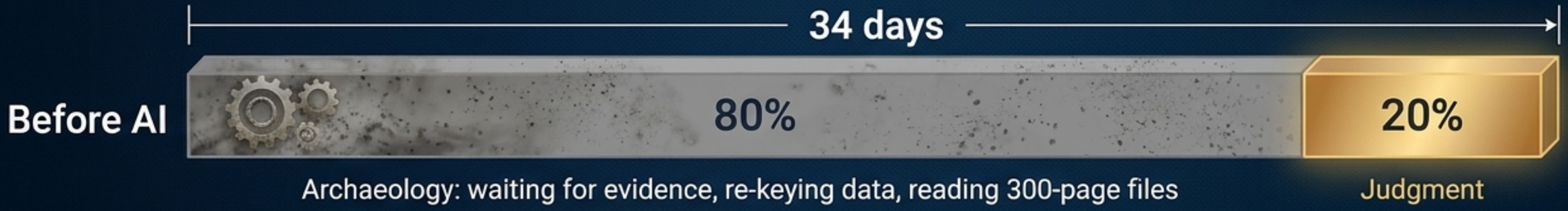
Shifting Time from Archaeology to Human Judgment



- **The Queue is a Symptom:** Northbridge found 1 in 5 applications was touched 11 times. AI attacks waits and rework first.
- **The AI Dividend:** By extracting handwritten data, checking completeness, and matching evidence, AI eliminates the drudgery. Efficiency targets never apply to the human judgment phase.

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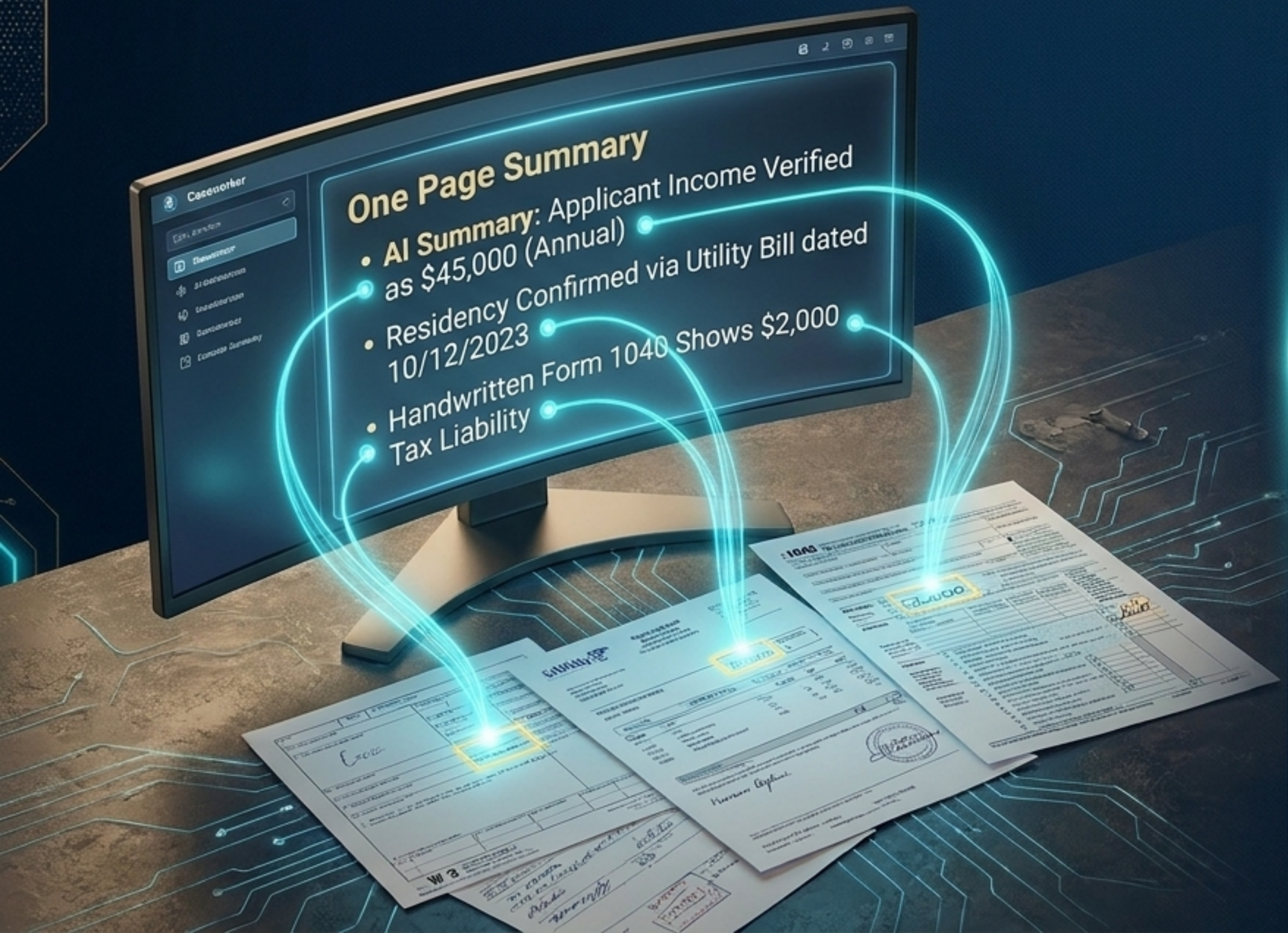
Trustable Summaries Link Every Claim to its Source



The Citation Rule: Every sentence of fact in an AI summary traces to a record entry the officer can open in one click.

Protecting the Original: The original document outranks its extraction in any dispute. If a handwritten amount conflicts with the AI extraction, the officer corrects it, and system learns.

Appeals are Data: Overturns are quality alarms. Finding that 40% of appeals succeeded due to “evidence held but not seen” points to a retrieval defect, not an applicant failure.

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Measuring Physical Reality Against Written Code

- **Standards as Code:** Deterministic rules engines test measurable standards (height, setback, density) instantly. AI reads the drawings, extracting dimensions directly from CAD/PDF sources.
- **Constraints Surfaced Early:** Flood, heritage, and contamination layers are mapped at pre-application.
- **Human Enforcement:** AI flags the 18cm boundary violation, but the planning officer retains discretion to approve the permit or enforce the code based on material considerations.

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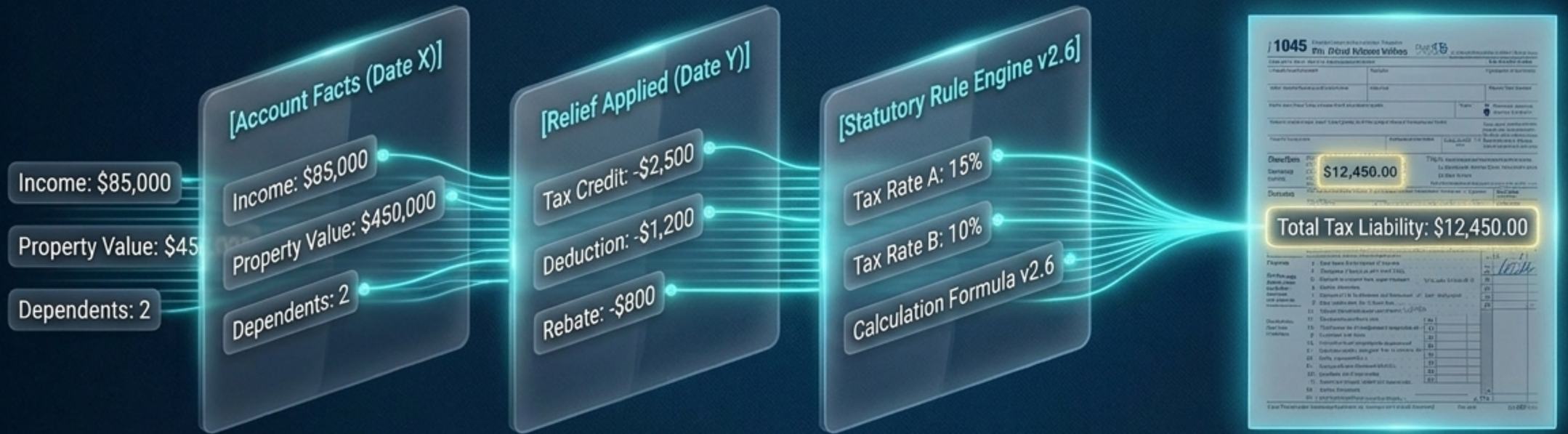
An AI-Generated Bill Must Be Human-Reproducible



Versioned Truth: Tax calculations must run on the correct, dated version of the rules engine.

Traceable Adjustments: For every material figure, the AI identifies the facts used, labels their origin, and shows exactly how a rate, relief, or officer adjustment changed the total.

Presumption of Honesty: Most incorrect payments are errors, not deliberate fraud. Compliance checks are proportionate, explained, and closable.

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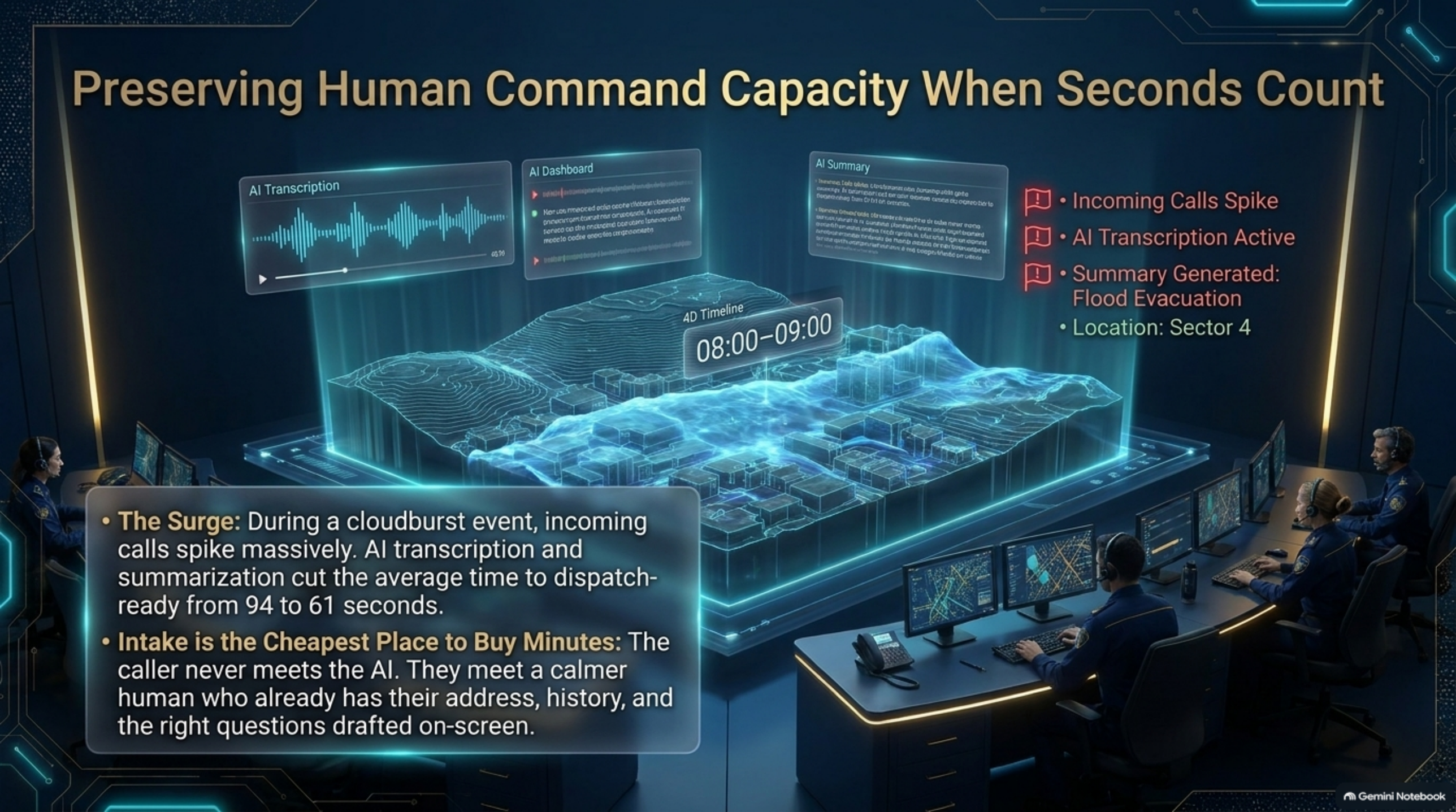
Preserving Human Command Capacity When Seconds Count



- **The Surge:** During a cloudburst event, incoming calls spike massively. AI transcription and summarization cut the average time to dispatch-ready from 94 to 61 seconds.
- **Intake is the Cheapest Place to Buy Minutes:** The caller never meets the AI. They meet a calmer human who already has their address, history, and the right questions drafted on-screen.

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Conflicting Claims Require Human Resolution, Not Averaging

Preserving the Uncertainty Radius

If a mobile device pin and a caller's description differ, the AI does not automatically snap to an address or average the distance.

The Location Bundle

The system displays both conflicting claims alongside their uncertainty radii. The human dispatcher assesses the mismatch, verifies the true location, and retains absolute command over the dispatch decision.

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Connecting Records While Preserving the Person

- **Identity Linkage is a Decision:** A 99% probabilistic data match between two names is a candidate for review, not an automated merge. A human steward confirms the link.
- **Permissions Travel with Data:** Access rules are enforced at the API interface.
- **Reversible History:** Corrections are made at the source and automatically propagate to all receiving systems, with a visible audit trail.

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Procure What You Can Independently Verify and Cleanly Exit

Buy Outcomes, Keep the Crown Jewels:
The content store, evaluation sets, resident data, and rules engines remain owned by the government.
Never surrender the source of truth.

Evaluate on Real Data:
Shortlisted suppliers must run their models on the city's held-out set of real, anonymized cases—not on polished vendor demo data.

The Exit Drill:
Exit tests (data formats, configurations, logs) are demonstrated and contracted before signature, not negotiated during departure.

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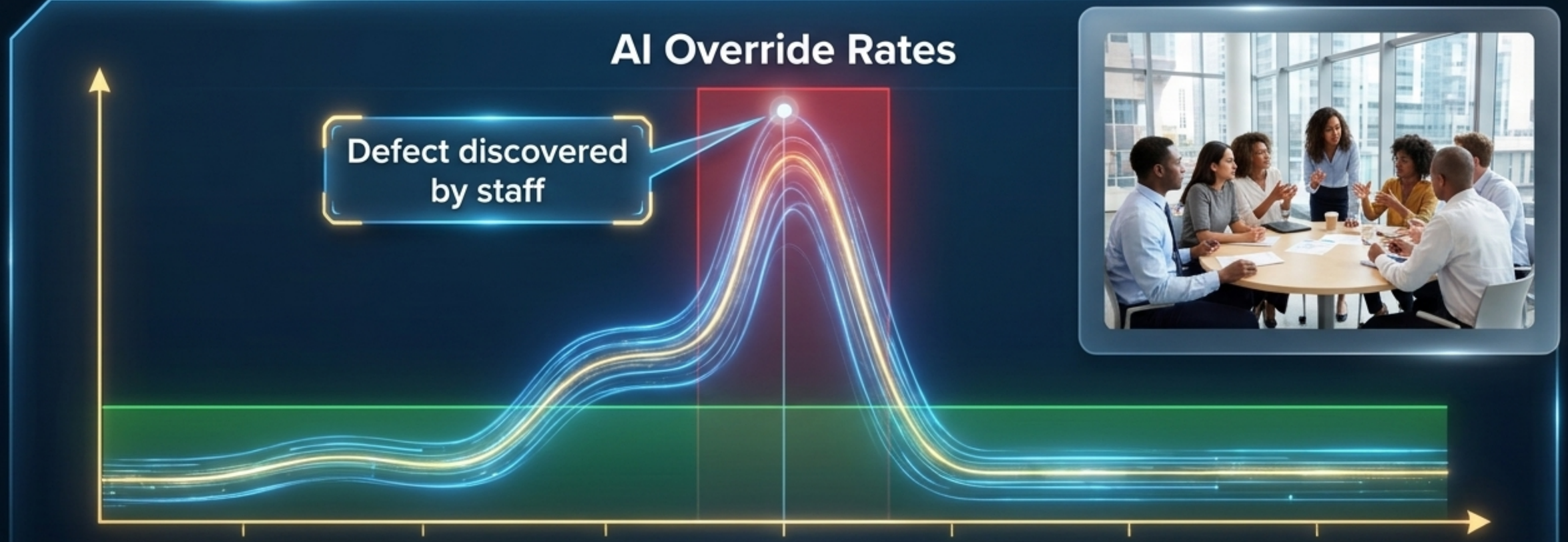
A Rising Override Rate is a Signal of Healthy Governance



- **Protect the Challenge:** When a team's AI override rate doubles, it is often a sign of improved checking or a newly discovered defect—not staff defiance.
- **Avoid the Rubber Stamp:** Penalizing overrides or requiring supervisor approval for every challenge adds friction exactly where human judgment is needed most.
- **Workarounds are Signals:** Staff routing around a tool are reporting a systemic defect. The desk that officers work around produces a shadow process that assurance cannot see.

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The Civic AI Risk & Control Matrix

	T1 - Internal Productivity	T2 - Resident Information	T3 - Case Influence	T4 - Decision-Adjacent
Examples	**Examples:** Search, drafting	**Examples:** Grounded guidance, translation	**Examples:** Triage, document extraction	**Examples:** Eligibility, enforcement support
Impact	**Impact:** Low	**Impact:** Moderate	**Impact:** High (shapes human work)	**Impact:** Critical (liberty/rights)
Control	**Control:** Standard guidance, spot checks	**Control:** Retrieval-only, mandatory citations, feedback routes	**Control:** Human decision on every case, quarterly equity reporting	**Control:** Executive sign-off, independent evaluation, strict adherence to the Stop List

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Capability vs. Authority: Dividing the Civic Workflow

	AI Domain	Human Domain
Benefits Eligibility	Extracts handwritten income, flags missing forms	Weighs hardship, signs final entitlement decision
Permitting & Zoning	Measures spatial dimensions, checks code rules	Assesses design amenity, balances community objections
Emergency Dispatch	Transcribes calls, bundles conflicting location radii	Determines triage grade, commits response vehicles
Procurement	Flags non-compliant bid language, summarizes vendor capabilities	Scores the bid against published criteria

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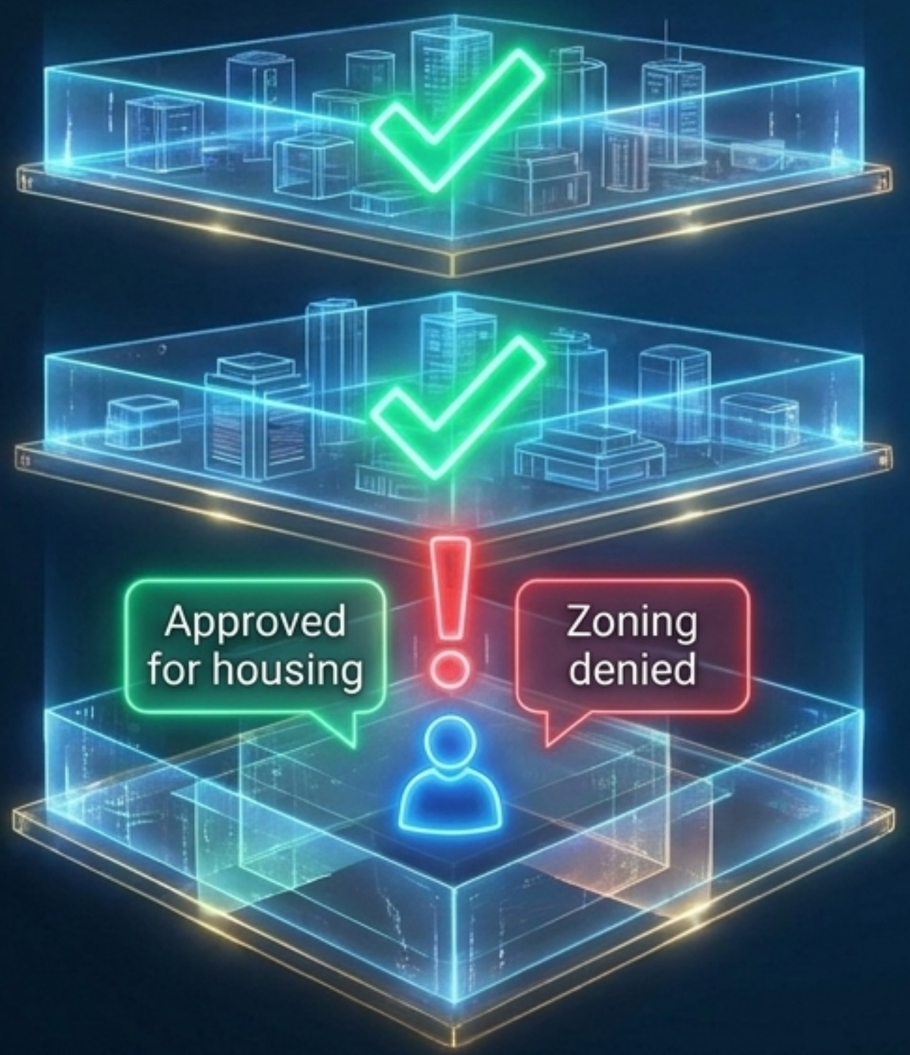
Optimizing Departments Creates Efficiency. Governing the Portfolio Creates Trust.

Department of Benefits

Department of Permitting

The Intersection



- **The Portfolio Contradiction:** Individual departments can pass all internal quality checks while the overall cross-department citizen journey fails.

- **Testing the Whole Journey:** A household may interact with tax, benefits, and permitting simultaneously. Capstone assurance requires testing the citizen's journey end-to-end to find contradictions that isolated metrics miss.

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The Six Gates of Portfolio Assurance

CP5 Sign & Publish: Document the officers' decisions and publish the portfolio statement.

CP0 Count: Reconcile the register with actual procurement spend and staff use.

CP4 Remediate: Fix, pause, or retire weak uses. Assign owners and deadlines to open findings.

CP1 Classify: Assign risk tiers, check the stop list, and name accountable officers.

CP3 Test: Walk the resident journey. Test for distribution, drift, and outage handling.

CP2 Evidence: Assemble the assurance file. Trace every claim to a dated record.

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Scrutiny in Public is a Feature, Not a Failure

Public Register: Case Triage AI

Purpose:	Summarizes incoming benefits forms.
Human Owner:	Director of Casework.
Data Used:	Submitted applicant forms only.
Appeal Route:	Click here to request a human review of this summary.

- **Disclose Outstanding Findings:** At sign-off, material open findings are disclosed with a description of the risk, a named owner, and a closure date.
- **Transparency is a Control:** Services that build for scrutiny get its protection. Errors are found early, claims are kept honest, and legitimacy is renewed in public.

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Assurance is the Product the Public Actually Receives
The Final Blueprint: Government may use AI to prepare, check, find, and draft. But a named human officer must decide, sign, record, and answer, every single time.
The Ultimate Standard: The public is entitled to trust the civic AI portfolio because they are entitled to read the file that proves it works. Trust is the record, kept honestly, in public.
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